At the gates of death.

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Evidence abstract

Apoptosis that proceeds via the mitochondrial pathway involves mitochondrial outer membrane permeabilization (MOMP), responsible for the release of cytochrome c and other proteins of the mitochondrial intermembrane space.

This essential step is controlled and mediated by proteins of the Bcl-2 family.

The proapoptotic proteins Bax and Bak are required for MOMP, while the antiapoptotic Bcl-2 proteins, including Bcl-2, Bcl-xL, Mcl-1, and others, prevent MOMP.

Different proapoptotic BH3-only proteins act to interfere with the function of the antiapoptotic Bcl-2 members and/or activate Bax and Bak.

Here, we discuss an emerging view, proposed by Certo et al.

in this issue of Cancer Cell, on how these interactions result in MOMP and apoptosis.

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Evidence checklist

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Source continuity

The canonical evidence above remains the authoritative retrieval target.